vigilant in controlling the surge and not let their guard down. Dispatches of advisories sent by the Ministry of Home Affairs and the MoHFW to the state leadership fell on deaf ears. Most chief ministers took for granted that if the surge was to come, it was going to be the Centre's problem and not theirs. Painfully, the prime minister repeatedly reiterated in his constant discourse with the chief ministers about the need to ramp up testing and contact tracing, the need to look out for mutations, the need to strengthen ambulance networks and many other vital issues.

I now understand that his intent was to entrust the state leadership and the elected chief ministers with more responsibility because he believed that they were equals in the exercise of keeping the nation safe. That in my opinion was a misjudgment of the abilities of various chief ministers. Several chief ministers hardly cared about the security of the nation and the safety of India, putting party politics above everything else.

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As of July, India's vaccination drive was yet to pick up the kind of speed that was needed to rapidly inoculate the country to meet the year-end target of vaccinating all 130 billion Indians. At this point, vaccination drives in other larger countries were achieving much more coverage than ours—a major reason being that the wealthy nations had invested large sums of money into vaccine manufactures, considering it to be risk funding, right from mid-2020. While India too had undertaken its own kind of risk funding by incubating companies with solid vaccine candidates, we obviously didn't have the risk appetite to put in billions of dollars into foreign companies whose candidates had not even begun Phase III vaccine trials, let alone demonstrate strong data. However, due to the pressure put on the government during the second wave to ramp up the pace of vaccinations, NEGVAC had started having advanced discussions with Pfizer and Moderna, despite their disagreeable terms. We changed our policy so that these candidates, which were now approved by the WHO or approved by regulatory authorities in Japan, Europe, the US or the UK and by now had immunized billions of people across the world would, not need to conduct bridge trials in India. However, NEGVAC was clear in its approach, closely guided by the prime minister, that unless a fair deal was arrived at, India was not going to get strong-armed into any agreements